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« Daniil Medvedev admitted that losing regularly to the new Big Two has sapped his motivation »

Andrey Rublev, another volatile top-10 Russian, is notorious for his combustible temper and occasional masochism on the ATP Tour. A year ago, he bloodied his knee with a vicious racket swing in frustration against Alcaraz. During Rublev's 6-4, 5-7, 6-2 round-robin loss to the mild-mannered Casper Ruud, the Russian's demons returned, and he smashed his racket on the court after losing serve to go down 2-1 in the deciding set.

Ruud, coached by his father Christian, a former top-40 player, takes a philosophical approach to the vicissitudes of the Tour.

Reflecting on his third straight ATP Finals semifinal, Ruud remarked, "Tennis is interesting sometimes. I don't know what I'm doing better this week than in the last weeks"—where he lost his opening match in six of his last seven tournaments. "The only thing I can really feel is serving; I'm serving really good, so hopefully I can keep it going tomorrow — I'm going to need it."

Alas, not even exceptional serving or the Norwegian's superb topspin forehand could stop the irresistible force that Sinner has become. Nor could the advice of *Tennis Channel* analyst Prakash Amritraj, the genial son of Indian tennis icon Vijay Amritraj: "You need delusional confidence to beat the top guy."

Ruud had won 11 of his 12 titles on clay, but on fast indoor hard courts, he became cannon fodder. As expected, Sinner pummelled the world No. 6 Ruud in a 6-1, 6-2 masterclass, highlighted by 23 winners against only nine unforced errors.

The near-flawless Italian seized 12 of the first 15 points, saved the only two break points he faced in the fifth game, and reeled off 12 of the last 15 points, finishing the rout with two forehand winners and a service ace.

The other semifinal was both predictably close and unpredictable. Alexander Zverev had risen to a career-high No. 2 after reaching the French Open final and claiming